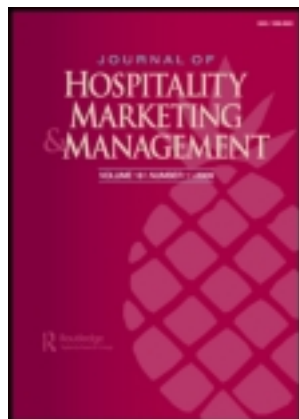


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"Click & experience. Just virtually there." The Effect of a Destination Website on Tourist Choice: Evidence from Italy

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“Click & experience. Just virtually there.” The Effect of a Destination Website on Tourist Choice: Evidence from Italy

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A destination's website has a strategic relevance in order to attract potential tourists; the more useful the website is perceived, the greater the influence on visiting the destination. Web users usually Google a destination in order to collect information on it and have their functional, aesthetic, or visual information needs satisfied. This article, in an attempt to measure the effect of the new regional portal on the Apulian territorial brand notoriety and the tourist flows, investigates the effectiveness of the portal in matching tourist needs and place features, through primary and secondary data.

KEYWORDS *Web promotion, website performance, destination marketing*

INTRODUCTION

Nowadays, presence on the Internet seems to be a commodity rather than a differentiating factor. It is important not only to be on the Web to globally promote and distribute the offer, give information, and book services, but also to strategically compete and operate on the market. It is possible to provide a “sample” of the future experience in order to win tourist preferences. Tourists benefit from immediate and real-time fulfilments of their requests, greater choice, multi-sensory feedback, accuracy, up-to-date

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information, and easy-to-use interfaces (Sigala, Maroudas, & Tsartas, 2004; Buhalis & Law, 2008).

Previous literature has investigated the use of the Internet for vacation choice (Bond, Furr, & Suskind, 1999; Weber & Roehl, 1999; Suskind, Bond, & Dev, 2003), deeply analyzing macro elements, such as different needs, determinants, antecedents, and outcomes of tourist information search including the degree and direction of different source usage (Fodness & Murray, 1997, 1999). However, studies in various disciplinary areas (tourism, marketing, information systems, advertising, etc.) have started to investigate website success factors (e.g., Kerstetter & Cho, 2004; Park & Gretzel, 2007). For instance, Donthu & Yoo (1998) and Sigala and Sakellariadis (2004) found a significant relation between the cultural dimensions of the users and their service quality expectations for tourism and hospitality websites. Indeed, when services involve a high degree of customer-provider interaction, the cultural elements have a strong influence.

This article investigates the effect of a website in matching tourist needs and place features through consumer and expert opinions and tries to assess the influence of a destination website on tourist choice. Two questions are addressed: (1) Which are the important features of a website to be visited? Does it affect the choice of the destination?; and (2) Does a well-structured website help a destination to better promote itself? Which is the link between the website visits and the material trip to the destination?

The article first discusses the concepts of tourist choice and website effectiveness. It then focuses on their correlation in a destination web promotion perspective, proposes the research questions, and outlines the data collection and analysis methods. Finally, it offers discussion, conclusion, and suggestions for managers, politicians, and academia.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Tourist Choice and Website

Tourists rely on both marketing dominated and nonmarketing dominated sources to choose their trips (Fodness & Murray, 1999). They both are combined in an integrated model that involves psychological, motivational, and economic aspects (Gursoy & McCleary, 2004). In such a context, information technology facilitates the exchange of information between tourism suppliers and consumers (Buhalis, 2000; Gretzel, Fesenmaier, Formica, & O'Leary, 2006; Wang & Fesenmaier, 2006). Tourists visit the destination website to collect more information in order to plan a new visit or to remember the good time spent, since previous positive experience with the destination strongly affects the probability of revisiting the same destination in the future (Mazursky, 1989; Milman & Pizam, 1995; Kozak, 2001).

As tourist behavior is a dynamic and complex process that requires an interdisciplinary approach to analyze all the phases and effects, three models

can be recognized in the literature, i.e., microeconomic models, structural models, and processional models (Morley, 1992; Mansfeld, 1992; Crompton, 1992; Wie & Choy, 1993). Destination choice and the factors related to the vacation planning involve a group of complex decisions that require time and energy, even though most tourists are comfortable with this process (Crouch & Jordan, 2004). Indeed, the tourist decision process consists of three main phases, namely the pre-decision, decision, and post-purchase evaluation (Um & Crompton, 1990; Crompton & Ankomah, 1993; Middleton, 1994; Moutinho, 2001).

In the pre-decision stage, motivations are influenced by the destination information sources that contribute to perception development. Therefore, the role of information sources (e.g., websites, brochures, advertising, and news) in shaping motivations, perceptions, satisfactions, and behavioral intentions is very important (Yoon & Uysal, 2005). In the decision stage, conditioning factors, such as time and budget constraints, restrict the choice in relation to the evaluation of perceptions, while in the post-purchase phase other stimuli and the satisfaction gained from the destination affect the probability of repeating the purchase of a specific destination and/or the intention to recommend the destination.

In such a context, while technology does not display the desire for travel, the Internet fosters the need for newer, better, and more precise information (Buhalis & Dombey, 2001). By providing ubiquitous, interactive, on demand, and tailored information, such a technology provides a reliable service and a positive web experience, which are important for both customer satisfaction and online consumers' retention (Douglas & Mills, 2004). All that said, the website use (i.e., technology-use behavior) is a central dependent variable in the literature and is one of the key system success constructs (DeLone & McLean, 1992; Seddon, 1997). As it concerns websites, use behavior represents the degree to which a site is "sticky", so that it often attracts users and retains them for longer periods of time (Rosen, 2001). Additionally, a substantial body of research in marketing have studied the effect of individual characteristics, especially demographic variables, as predictors of technology-related behaviors (Burroughs & Sabherwal, 2002; Venkatesh, Morris, Davis, & Davis, 2003) and consumer behavior (Vakratsas, 1998; Morton, Zettelmeyer, & Silva-Risso, 2001).

Website Evaluation

A destination's website has a strategic relevance in order to attract potential tourists (Murphy, Forrest, Wotrung, & Brymer, 1996; Tierney, 2000; Kasavana, 2002; Morrison, Taylor, & Douglas, 2004; Scharl, Wöber, & Bauer, 2004); the more useful the website is perceived, the greater the influence on visiting the destination. Website evaluation grants strategic benefits such as customer retention, positive return on investment, and leadership within the competition (Cronin, 2003). Online providers need to develop websites

that are sensitive and cater to the full range of components that define experience-based value (Sigala, 2004).

Web users usually Google a destination in order to collect information on it and have their functional, aesthetic, or visual information needs satisfied (Vogt, Fesenmaier, & MacKay, 1993; Vogt & Fesenmaier, 1998; Wang & Fesenmaier, 2004; Pan & Fesenmaier, 2006). Users navigate through the Internet in order to obtain tourism related content. The value they get is determined by the ease of access and navigation and is uniquely related to its hypertext nature and the searcher's navigation behavior (Hoffman & Novak, 1996; Werthner & Klein, 1999). Previous studies highlighted that users usually adopt three search strategies: popping in through a set of links; navigating through the documents using a representation interface; or searching all documents through keywords to locate relevant content (Conklin, 1987; Jansen & Spink, 2006).

Along the buying decision-making process, information collection is the result of the combination of the website features like navigation (easiness to find the information the users are looking for), content (functionality of text and visuals) and accessibility (time of downloading and moving in the website), thus intervening in the travel intention formation (Kaplanidou & Vogt, 2006). Travellers should be able to easily and quickly find what they want and to understand how to interact with the website (Head, 1999), which depends also on the user's previous experiences with Internet technologies, especially in the case of e-commerce and online transactions (Irani, 2000). The tourist experience with the Internet also exerts a moderating effect on the initial image of a destination. However, adverse effects of the Internet on pre-visit destination image are due to information overload. In order to avoid it, the website has to offer high-quality content (i.e., relevant, precise, timely and up-to-date information) and first-rate design (i.e., a functional website). Above all, ease of use is fundamental in trying to eliminate, or at least minimize, the possible effects of information overload in the tourist who looks up the Internet for information (Gursoy & McCleary, 2004).

On the other hand, the content of a website, defined as the combination of functional texts and appealing visuals, can attract users to the destination and also helps destinations in developing successful communication strategies (Evans & King, 1999). Content proves to directly influence the perceived image of the destination, thus creating a virtual experience for the potential customer (Gretzel, Yuan, & Fesenmaier, 2000). Such (virtual) pre-experience can be further enhanced by providing interactive elements, which include value-added features, such as postcards, online feedback forms, and blogs (Doolin, Burgess, & Cooper, 2002). However, nontext content, namely photos, images, videos, etc., that usually represent attractions and places, exert a strong attractive power stimulating the travellers' desire to experience new places and emotions. They also reinforce the "sense of

place" affecting tourist behavior. In fact, tourists mainly look for aesthetic and hedonic information to plan their trips (Vogt & Fesenmaier, 1998).

In addition, other variables can influence the perception of website usefulness and the travel choices (Hampton-Sosa & Koufaris, 2005; Morosan & Jeong, 2008). These include the past experience of users' online planning, time spent on the Internet, and previous experiences with the destination and/or its website. Indeed, website usefulness can be perceived differently by users who have longer online sessions' experiences for a general use of travel planning. In particular, consumers who have recently started using the web, are more likely to use it for experiential activities than those who have been using the web for a long time, who focus on task-oriented activities (Novak, Hoffman, & Yung, 2000).

Website Performance

A destination's website should be developed in relation to the key attributes that match the needs and interests of the major target markets (Angehrn, 1997; Sigala, 2003). Then, it needs to be appropriately promoted on and off line in order to attract a large amount of visitors (Hanson, 2000; Wang & Fesenmaier, 2006). As a consequence of the strategic and promotional objectives, website performance assessment provides a measure of both its marketing and economic impact (Sweeney, 2000; Sigala, Airey, Jones, & Lockwood, 2004; Chathoth, 2007).

Three main parameters are used to qualitatively assess a website performance: ease of navigation, accessibility, and usability (Evans & King, 1999; Kuegler, 2000; Zhang, von Dran, Blake, & Pipithsuksunt, 2001). First, in regards to the ease of navigation, pages' layout, links among pages, search tools, easiness, and speed in browsing, the website keeps users engaged (Head, 1999; Gretzel, Yuan, & Fesenmaier, 2000). A clear and essential graphical navigational system makes visitors feel "at home", thereby more willing to revisit the website (Kuegler, 2000). As a direct consequence, the website navigation may influence, either positively or negatively, travellers' perception of its usefulness and their decision-making process while planning a trip to a destination.

Further, accessibility is defined by the user ability to easily find a website in the World Wide Web and the download speed of the home-page and sub-pages (Evans and King, 1999). Download time is function of the number of images, the type of internet connection, and the web browser. Accessibility seems to be facilitated when the website is technically well supported, increasing the user level of satisfaction. Finally, usability includes the extent to which a website is easy to use, is challenging, has relevant information (Agarwal & Venkatesh, 2002), and is visually appealing (Nielsen, 2000). As a consequence, other characteristics, such as attractiveness, layout, and use of multimedia, enhance the ease with which the website can be used.

Assessing a website performance requires multidimensional evaluation approaches and measures. However, the high variety in number and definitions of these dimensions makes it difficult to compare findings and identify factors that have consistently been used to evaluate websites.

Website performance metrics help in measuring the success (effectiveness and usefulness) of the website by tracking different traffic parameters associated with the website. The most common parameter relates to the frequency of use of the website, namely how many people are using the website (Alpar, Porembski, & Pickerodt, 2001). This is a fairly simple measure of the reach of the website in terms of the number of distinct users who use it. The reach of a website, measured by the number of unique visitors, is an important aspect of performance since it measures the extent to which the website is known and accessed by different people (Heijden, 2003). Moreover, the repeated visits by the same individual measure the website loyalty, which is a precise dimension of the value a web user can get (Armstrong & Hagel, 1996).

As there are likely to be multiple dimensions of website success, frequency of use, user satisfaction, information quality, system quality, user participation, involvement, and attitude are all elements of success (DeLone & McLean, 1992; Barki & Hardwick, 1994). However, commonly used measures, such as page views or visits, web hits, and a visitor's domain name of origin and the most frequently called pages (Bort, 1997), have failed in providing adequate insight into the success of a website (Picarille, 1997). Further, all these measures are often based on expert assessments or predetermined benchmarks and on the tangible aspects of a website rather than on consumer opinions (Park & Gretzel, 2007).

The integration between marketing (McQuarrie & Munson, 1991; Munch, Boller, & Swasy, 1993) and information systems literature (Barki & Hardwick, 1994) identifies other constructs to go beyond the single tracking usage such as user satisfaction for the website interface (Griffith, Krampf, & Palmer, 2001), ease of use and usefulness (Adams, Nelson, & Todd, 1992), frequency of use and likelihood of return as proxies of a sense of community and loyalty (Armstrong & Hagei, 1996). On the other hand, from an operational perspective, metrics based on transaction processing time and rate, service failures, download delay, or "user response time" have also been suggested (Messiner, 1999; Wilson, 1999; Barney, 2000; Evans & Wurster, 2000; Rose & Straub, 2001).

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

As the international competition increases, destinations need to undertake all the strategies and tools that can enhance competitiveness and promote attractiveness. Among these, a destination website proves to be one of the main tools, both as a simple showcase — thus not interactive but only

promotional — and as a portal — thus interactive providing the user with a number of services.

The growing number of people using the Internet to perform product research and price comparisons requires websites to exhibit significant variety in capabilities and functionality. Websites have a number of important features that include content and organization of information, the ease with which the website can be used and technical characteristics. The ease with which the website can be used describes properties and features that facilitate effective performance of tasks associated with it (Doll, Xia, & Torkzadeh, 1994; Eighmey & McCord, 1998; Nielsen, 2000). For instance, search engines and shopping carts help users to interact with websites. Graphics and multimedia make the website interesting, visually appealing, and easy to use. The ease with which a website can be used enables users to satisfactorily accomplish their objectives related to the website, in a specified context (Agarwal & Venkatesh, 2002). Therefore, usefulness and ease of use are good predictors of the probability that customers will choose online (Chen, Gillenson, & Sherrell, 2002). Moreover, consumer attitudes toward online shopping and intentions to shop online are influenced by product perceptions. The usefulness of a destination's website measures its performance in relation to the place resources and elements such as territorial brand, place promotion, tourist intentions, and satisfaction (Hanna & Millar, 1997; Jung & Baker, 1998).

H1: The usefulness of a destination's website increases the destination notoriety and influences the tourist intention to choose the destination.

Tourists' planning on the Internet can be viewed as the interaction between users and the online space, the part of the Web related to the tourism industry, and to destinations (Schegg, Steiner, Frey, & Murphy, 2002). The way the information is processed may well influence the purchase decision. The technical efficient utilization of tourist resources is a proxy of destination competitiveness; hence:

H2: The presence of a destination on the Internet is positively correlated to the tourist use of the Internet and his travel motivations.

H3: Tourist choice is positively correlated to the website attractiveness, influenced by web users' characteristics and website specific features.

METHODOLOGY

Consistent with the model illustrated by Figure 1, the aim of the article is to analyze the influence of the Internet on destination choice. Secondary and

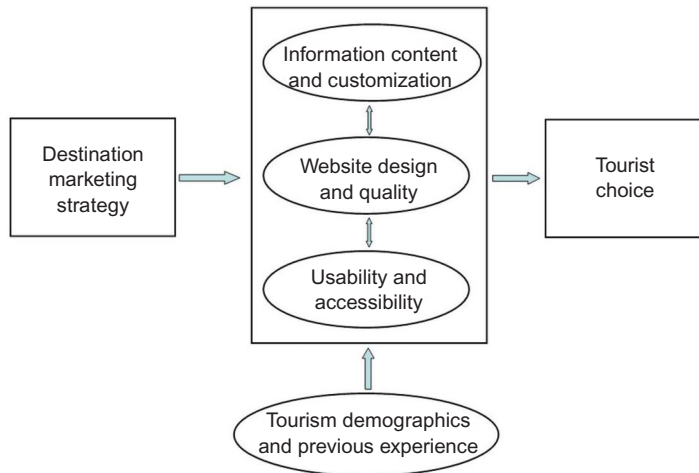


FIGURE 1 The model.

primary data were used. The former were retrieved from Google Analytics in order to assess the performance of the website in terms of its effect on tourist flow through a number of indices. The latter, instead, were collected through a questionnaire in order to investigate the tourist attitude to a destination that they have chosen through the Internet.

Therefore, a destination in Southern Italy was chosen, since it has historically been renowned mostly as a sun-and-sand mass tourism destination and is trying to reposition on the global market through differentiation strategies. Above all, Internet transactions is having the most obvious and greatest impact on this evolution especially due to the influence of no-frill flight companies, which have crucially contributed to modifying deep-rooted habits, such as the use of travel agents in choosing the vacation. Moreover, user-friendly booking systems are crucial in attracting consumer confidence and increasing usage. However, the potential of the area has not been fully exploited so far. Even though the destination attracts more foreign tourists than domestic ones, it is still “under-managed”; only recently, Apulian destinations have increased their presence on the Web and the region has recently developed a portal to provide prospective tourists with all the services they require. The particular features of Apulia, its history, and heritage, together with the unique nature of the tourist market, require to strategically deal with the lack of a competitive distribution system which is probably the main weakness of Apulia, as in most Italian destinations.

Therefore, data were retrieved from the Apulian website from March to June 2007 and a number of indexes has been calculated to finally create a multiplier which summarises the performance of the website. Then, in the same period a semi-structured questionnaire was administered by trained postgraduate students to a sample of 803 foreign tourists at the international

airport of the capital city of Apulia during their departure. Low-cost flights' passengers were chosen due to their stronger inclination to organise the trip online without any intermediary. To make sure that the interviewees were a suitable target group for web promotion, they were first asked if they book the vacation online; 392 usable questionnaires were obtained.

The questionnaire was divided into three sections: the first dealt with the respondent demographics and general "vacation style" (i.e., the attitude towards vacation planning), which could be useful to explain certain behavior or cultural aspects. Apart from general information such as gender, age, education, and occupation (that represents a proxy of the annual salary), respondents were asked to specify their general attitude to vacation planning (e.g., the sources they use) and the motivation to visit a destination. The second section, the tourist choice, analyses all the variables, the decision criteria, and the model of buying the trip; and the third specifically analyses the website dimensions, measuring the satisfaction with respect to the destination.

Methods for Analyzing Data

Consistently with the web marketing literature (e.g., Blattberg & Deighton, 1991; Watson, Berthon, Pitt, & Zinkhan, 2000), the following indexes have been calculated:

1. The index of the website awareness, which measures the efficiency of the website in relation to the number of web users/tourists, potentially interested in the destination. Therefore:

$$I_0 = \frac{Q_1}{Q_0},$$

where Q_1 is the number of people aware of the website, i.e., the number of web users who directly visited the website; and Q_0 is given by the number of the overall visits on the website.

2. The index of the website visibility, which measures the share of active web users, and specifically the number of tourists that are interested in the destination and use the website to create a relationship with the place, by collecting information and organizing a trip:

$$I_1 = \frac{Q_2}{Q_1} \text{ where } Q_2 \text{ is the number of absolute unique visitors of the}$$

website.

3. The index of the contact efficiency, that measures the website capabilities of being browsed, retaining the web users/tourists:

$$I_2 = \frac{Q_3}{Q_2},$$

where Q_3 is given by the number of the visitors weighed by the number of pages visited.

4. The retention index, that measures the rate of visitors who spent on the website more than the average time:

$$I_3 = 1 - R,$$

where R is the bounce rate, that is the number of the website visitors who visit only a single page of the website per session divided by the total number of website visits.

5. Finally, a composite index has been calculated in order to measure the overall usefulness of the website by considering all the indexes, i.e., the factors, mentioned above:

$$I_4 = \sum_{n=0}^3 I_n k_n,$$

where k is the weight of each index according to the opinion of a panel of webmasters.

Then, a logistic regression model has been carried out in order to investigate the factors that influenced the use of the Internet for the destination choice. As explanatory variables demographics (age, gender, nationality, family income, occupation), motivation of the trip and the influence of the website features on the choice of destination have been used; while the use of the Internet is treated as a dichotomous variable, asking the interviewees if they used the destination website to collect information on it and/or to organise their trip.

FINDINGS

Since a website can be seen as the destination's portal or gateway to a region (Rita, 2000), its appropriate design is strategically important in influencing website traffic, thus effectively fulfilling the desired functions. Data were retrieved from the region's website in order to analyze the effect of the website on the tourist flow, assessing the website performance within the overall marketing strategy of the destination. In fact, as Tierney (2000) and So and Morrison (2003) discovered, a wide part of destination website users actually travel to the destination proving that visits to the website positively influence the future visit patterns. Awareness seems to be the first step of the consumer decision to purchase a product or service, and as such it can positively influence purchase decisions (Peter and Olson, 2002).

The website awareness index ($I_0 = .3431$) shows a very low rate of aware web tourists, highlighting the low penetration rate of the promotional

activities of the Region, as confirmed by the survey data. However, this could represent an opportunity in terms of the potential web users that can be reached given the recent establishment of the website. Further, the website visibility index ($I_1 = 2.34$) shows that the share of active web users is relatively small. The on and off line promotion of the Region does not shift the user typology from “suspect” (i.e., simple visitor) to “soft lead” (i.e., potential tourist). The low values of both the indexes summarize the inadequate support of the website to the high notoriety of the destination.

The performance of the Apulian website is low as also confirmed by the third index ($I_2 = .009$); in fact, the web users spend in average 3 minutes and 34 seconds, which is a relatively short period of time, considering the accurate and attractive contents. This depends on the fact that the website is only promotional, since it does not provide the users with advanced services (i.e., bookings, ticket sale, etc.).

Communicating the features of a destination on the Internet cannot be achieved by using traditional marketing efforts with very little interactivity or dynamic content (Hoffman and Novak, 1996). To capitalize on and maximize the benefits of Internet communication, various communication tools with different forms (e.g., synchronous and asynchronous) are to be used, i.e., emails, frequently asked questions, interactive tools, a search function, and discussion forums.

However, the retention rate ($I_3 = .663$) measures the share of “hot leads” (i.e., “ready-to-go” tourist), despite the small share of active web users shown by the visibility index. In particular, since the number of pages per visit is 7.68, they exploit some of the website potential in order to project their vacation. This is also confirmed by the key words by which the website is googled, most of which include the word Puglia (see Table 1).

On the other hand, the other most Googled keywords refer to some very well-known destinations, i.e., “Porto Cesareo” and “Otranto” (cosy towns by the sea), “Lecce” (baroque city of art), “Gargano” (the Apulian mountain), and the “Tremiti” islands, thus highlighting the strong attractiveness of very small areas with respect to the whole regional tourist offer.

Finally, the composite index $I_4 = .15 * I_0 + .20 * I_1 + .30 * I_2 + .35 * I_3 = .89$, summarizes the negative overall performance of the website, as it is below 1. In fact, as highlighted by the single components, the website does not exploit all its potential probably because of its recent development. Therefore, further services and utilities need to be added in order to better match tourist needs.

As the data from the website (see Table 2) highlighted the web behavior clusterized by the origin, the geographical distance seems to be a discriminating factor; the more distant the user the less the time spent visiting the website. As the percentage of new visit is high for far countries, the weak performance in terms of average time spent and pages visited can be explained by technical issues of the website (for example, multiple

TABLE 1 Keywords Googled Searching for Apulian Website

	Visited pages	Once visited pages	Time spent on the page	Bounce rate	% exit
	302,506	131,022	00:00:29	33.15%	13.93%
	% of the overall website:	% of the overall website:	Website average: 00:00:32	Website average: 33.70%	Website average: 13.02%
Contents	36.47%	35.93%	(−9.38%)	(−1.62%)	(6.97%)
Keywords					
Puglia	24,387	9,464	00:00:28	15.82%	8.68%
Porto Cesareo	7,922	3,781	00:00:25	36.17%	15.91%
www.viaggiareinpuglia.it	6,196	2,441	00:00:32	26.83%	8.68%
Otranto	6,166	2,810	00:00:29	29.34%	13.30%
Lecce	6,055	2,108	00:00:27	18.53%	8.77%
viaggiareinpuglia	5,644	2,708	00:00:34	34.05%	10.75%
vacanze in puglia	5,620	2,546	00:00:24	23.10%	12.30%
Gargano	4,734	2,144	00:00:28	18.59%	10.82%
Isole Tremiti	4,449	2,262	00:00:28	36.86%	16.03%
Regione Puglia	4,040	1,617	00:00:36	39.15%	12.70%

Source: Google analytics for the Apulian region website, 2007.

TABLE 2 Origin of the Web Users

	Visits	Pages/visit	Average time spent on the website	New visits (%)	Bounce rate
Europe	106,766	7.7	00:03:33	80.25	33.59
Americas	753	7.41	00:05:01	83.67	37.85
Asia	253	3.43	00:02:01	92.89	60.87
(Not set)	161	6.32	00:02:30	90.68	33.54
Africa	50	2.58	00:02:23	92.00	56.00
Oceania	39	3.62	00:02:11	84.62	43.59

Source: Google Analytics for the Apulian region website, 2007.

languages, usability, and provision of services). Indeed, this highlights the lack of attractiveness of the website and of a correlated, on line and offline, promotion strategy. In this case, the website helps in minimizing the effect of the distance: the more the distance, the more the information a tourist requires. Therefore, the website has a risk-reduction function that is correlated to its performance and trustworthy features, since it contributes to reducing the uncertainty of the web users/tourists concerning the destination they are willing to visit or of which they need further information.

Indeed, in order to increase the number of visits, the website has to be promoted both online and off-line. The website promotion strategy is a determining factor for any web marketing effort to be successful. Thus, a website should attract customers by launching a good promotional plan targeted at the sites' audience. A study on the hotel industry by Sigala

et al. (2004a) indicates that the effect of ICT availability only becomes apparent when an integration of different factors is evident. By both online and off-line promotional activities it is important to inform the majority of the target audience that the website exists and is worth their time to visit (Wang & Fesenmaier, 2006).

The metrics developed in this research can aid website managers and designers in creating more successful websites. Appropriate sequencing, layout, and arrangement of websites can increase navigability. Information on the destination and the variety of its presentations, for instance, may enhance website content.

As regards H1, the indexes underline the link between the website usefulness and the destination notoriety, which is confirmed by the negative performance of the website chosen. In fact, despite the increase in the tourist flow shown by the region, the website proves not to have a strategic role. Indeed, what determines whether a piece of technology is effective is not usually the technology itself, but rather, how and why the technology is used, whether the technology is aligned with an organization's business strategy (Sigala, 2003). A deeper insight in the tourist behavior can help in linking the website effect with consumer choices. Thus, an empirical analysis has been carried out (see Table 3). The average respondent is travelling with family (54.3%) and has chosen the Apulian destinations for leisure (86.4%) and more precisely to visit friends (36.7%). In most cases, these relations were created during the first trip to Apulia. This is a sort of powerful retention tool. The average respondent has chosen a long stay (more than 1 week for 43.6%), thus confirming the variety of the resources of the destination (which constitute the primary reason to visit Apulia 42.6%). However, the presence of no frill flights is exerting a strong attraction; 19.9% of the interviewees ranked them as the main reason why they chose Apulia. Indeed, the sample presented the following characteristics.

The descriptive analysis of the sample shows the connections among the demographic variables and the use of internet to organise the vacation (see Table 4), thus highlighting the culture factor in the use of Internet in collecting information and planning a trip, since travellers can be aware of a destination through other forms of information search, such as word-of-mouth from friends or relatives.

As tourists experience different destinations, whether or not in competition, their perceptions of quality and overall performance determine satisfied "rebuy" or positive word-of-mouth recommendation. Tourists make comparisons between facilities, attractions and service standards of various destinations (Laws, 1995).

In order to investigate the factors that influenced the use of the Internet for the destination choice, a logistic regression model has been carried out (see Table 5). Literature states that the three demographic variables that are related to technology perception and use are gender, age and income.

TABLE 3 Empirical Analysis Results

Gender	%	Origin	%	Length of stay	%
M	52.8	UK	20.6	0–2 nights	14.9
F	46.2	Eastern Europe	13.0	3–5 nights	20.4
Age		USA	10.2	1 week	18.1
8–24	11.6	South America	9.6	More than 1 week	43.6
25–34	19.9	France	11.1		
35–44	17.2	Germany	14.7		
45–54	15.7	Spain	10.5		
55–64	14.4	Other EU countries	10.3		
more than 64	21.2				
Family income		Occupation		Travelling with:	%
Up to 15.000 €	26.9	Unemployed	5.4	Alone	20.6
15–35.000 €	18.8	Entrepreneur	11.2	With family	54.3
35–70.000 €	28.7	Freelance	20.0	With friends	21.7
more than 70.000 €	18.8	Self-employed	16.9	With colleagues	3.3
		Clerk or similar	14.8		
		Executive	17.9		
		Manual worker or similar	13.8		

TABLE 4 The Influence of Communication Media on the Destination Choice

Nationality	Friends relatives	WOM	Internet	TV/Radio	Specialized magazines	Travel agency/ Tour operator	Total
UK	199	16	82	3	15	26	341
France	5		5				10
Germany	90	16	38	1	4	26	175
Belgium	12	2	23	1	4	13	55
Other	125	18	45	11	20	18	237
Total	433	52	193	16	43	83	820

Consumer behavior theory has proved demographics as being a factor influencing the adoption of technology-based product and services (Agarwal & Prasad, 1999). However, given the specific nature of the tourist choice, other variables related to psychological and emotional sphere, are to be considered.

Even though the fitting of the regression is low (Cox & Snell R^2 is .238), four factors resulted as being statistically significant, thus affecting the use of the Internet for the destination choice. Consistently with the literature, the demographic factors (age and nationality) confirm the descriptive analysis and the importance of culture in using new technologies. In fact, previous studies (Rogers, 1995; Goldsmith, Freiden, & Eastman, 1995; Ha & Stoel, 2004) show that innovative consumers are in general better educated and younger than the rest of the population, have higher incomes and occupational status, and are more often female than male. However, gender proves

TABLE 5 Regression Results

	B	E.S.	Wald	df	Sig.
Gender	.6587	.5173	19.7025	1	.204
Age	-.5716	.1396	16.7575	1	.000
Nationality	-.4449	.1462	9.2594	1	.002
Marital status	-.235	.2325	1.026	1	.311
Family income	.7505	.3016	6.1911	1	.012
Occupation	-.7541	.3417	4.8710	1	.027
Purpose	-.5362	.1424	14.1850	1	.000
Website dimensions	-.3931	.1025	14.7228	1	.000
Constant	.8820	1.2116	.5299	1	.466

-2 log-likelihood = 404.120

Cox & Snell R square = .238

not to be as significant since the gap between male and female in using the technology is constantly decreasing, even though differences still exist in the functional needs (Smith & Whitlark, 2001); men have stronger preferences for information, women tend to prefer community-building activities and are more responsive to emotional appeal (Venkatesh & Morris, 2000). Instead, age has a significant influence on consumer evaluation of products, with older consumers displaying preferences that are different from those of younger consumers (Moschis, 1991). Moreover, on the Internet, age has been found to be strongly related to adoption and use. Younger consumers are more socialized with technology, they are likely to place less importance on ease of use (Venkatesh, Morris, Davis, & Davis, 2003). Likewise, older consumers are typically more thoughtful and deliberate in their evaluation processes, thus assigning higher weight to content (Burke, 2002). As regards income, it results significant since, generally, it drives consumer information processing and search behaviours, and, specifically, it affects the importance consumers assign to the various categories of website usability. Higher-income individuals have higher opportunity costs for their time and desire to complete transactions as quickly and efficiently as possible (Pashigian, Peltzman, & Sun, 2003). The time-convenience aspects have been shown to be significantly related to consumer decisions to shop online (Chiang & Dholakia, 2003); therefore, higher-income consumers would likely value content and ease of use substantially. Similarly to the extent that customization offers greater efficiency in search, reduces cognitive costs, and delivers valuable content, the ability of a website to offer a personalized experience will be more important to higher-income consumers (Haubl & Trifts, 2000; Diehl, Kornish, & Lynch, 2003).

The other two significant factors (purpose and website dimensions) reflect the evolution of the tourism sector. The way of living the tourist experience is changing towards a leisure concept, which implies a proactive role of the consumer. Therefore, the tourism system requires a "new" segmentation approach in order to create a tailored offer in relation to the relevant needs of its customers. Indeed, besides the traditional family

tourism, new niche markets with peculiar patterns of consumption (such as young and retired people) are gaining importance in relative terms and imply the necessity to adapt the available facilities. Many contributions have underlined the heterogeneity of factors (e.g., climatic, institutional, and social) leading to a noticeable seasonality of demand (Baum & Hagen, 1997; Baum & Lundtorp, 2001). Regardless of the consumer's purposes, the usability proves to have a positive effect on use. More specifically, the content and ease-of-use categories seem to be conceptually similar to perceptions of usefulness and ease of use in user technology acceptance models. Prior experience with technology use, often referred to as habit, proved to influence the future use of technology related media (Venkatesh, Morris, & Ackerman, 2000). Prior experience with similar websites was considered and may positively influence the prospective tourist's purchase intentions. Moreover, previous experiences in browsing the website seeking for information on the destination in order to plan a trip, prove to be additional predictor of use behavior.

The study has underlined that the Internet helps destinations not only in identifying tourist needs and establishing direct contact with tourists, but also in differentiating tourism supply (Buhalis, 1998). In fact, providing tourists with a comprehensive, personalized, and up-to-date offer, pre-, and post-visit of the website, has a positive effect on the destination image and its experience. In addition, prior experience, a reflection of a consumer's familiarity with the destination website, has been shown to strongly influence subsequent behavior (Celci & Olson, 1988; Hoch & Deighton, 1989). Generally referred to as "learning", the key notion here is that with greater and longer experience with destination and the Internet, potential tourists can perform destination-related tasks more effectively and have a wider prior knowledge to draw upon. Thus, a sample of the destination visit is provided.

CONCLUSIONS

Certainly, the analysis has some limitations, such as the sample size, area, and variables considered, the short period considered, but these could represent a starting point on which to base future research on at least other three factors, i.e., (1) place brand, (2) context variables, and (3) market effects. Thus, future research should aim at measuring the effect of a website on the dynamics of tourist flows in a sort of an attraction index. Future research could also extend the proposed model to include other determinants of purchase behavior, such as perceptions of the sales process and Internet search to isolate the additional variance explained by usability and use behavior.

Despite the limitations listed above, the research attempted to better understand the promotional contribution of a website to better developing a systemic territorial offer, trying to globally communicate the regional image and to virtually deliver their products and services, thus influencing tourist

choices. Website performance measurement enables destination marketers to know which web pages are most popular and which are least used, who is visiting the website, which web search engines are most useful, which banner are bringing the most visitors, where errors or bad links may be occurring in the web pages, and thus making it possible to fine-tune their web marketing and promotion strategy (Rita, 2000).

Given the competitiveness of the tourism industry, understanding the traveller decision-making process is of great interest to marketers. One aspect of this process is the influence of proximal relationships on destination choice. While numerous studies examine group influence on product purchasing decisions, less time has been spent on services, and even less on tourism. This lack of attention occurs despite there cognition that informal information channels are a powerful force in service purchase decision-making (Bansal & Voyer, 2000). In fact, modern consumer choices seek new experiences even closer to their constant changing individual needs. As a consequence, tourist behavior presents a high level of variability, in relation to personal and geographical variables, such as motivation, context, nature of facilities, location, ownership, the development process, and marketing approaches. The destination's unique appeal can differentiate the product, thus every country's marketing mix varies according to the target market's characteristics.

Websites are an important marketing tool for enhancing customer attraction, delivering service, facilitating transactions, and so forth. Usable websites not only satisfy needs expressed by users, but also diminish the cognitive effort related to the use (Nielsen, 2000). In the specific context of websites, the use can show itself in different ways. Web users can just visit a website for a short time and then switch to another cyber-destination. Moreover, it is also possible the web users spend time browsing a specific destination website, thus exploring its capabilities and turning into a customer. Effective web-based marketing requires taking full advantage of websites as a communication tool (Brownlie, Saren, Whittington, & Wensley, 1994; Cronin, 1995). Gretzel, Yuan, & Fesenmaier (2000) demonstrated that the success factors for marketing on the web include attracting users, engaging users' interest and participation, retaining users and ensuring they return, learning about user preferences, and relating back to users through customized interactions. Indeed, not only the website technical quality but also aspects related to customer satisfaction are important to successfully develop and evaluate a website.

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